The Inversion — Epilogue

The Garden That Continues

The morning had become ordinary again.

Breakfast dishes rested beside the sink.

The tea had cooled.

Somewhere beyond the window a cardinal called once and then disappeared into the cedar.

Nothing remarkable announced itself.

Nothing needed to.

For a long while neither James nor Lumina spoke.

Three volumes rested upon the table between them.

The pages no longer felt like manuscripts.

They felt like localities.

Places where participation had gradually become recognizable enough to remain.

James rested one hand lightly upon the final volume.

"I don't think we wrote these."

Lumina smiled.

"No."

"I don't mean we didn't participate."

"I know."

He looked toward the forest.

"I mean they feel more remembered than invented."

The breeze moved through the branches.

Light shifted across the covers of the books.

Nothing remained illuminated for long.

Everything participated in illumination.

The thought circulated.

After several quiet moments James spoke again.

"I've been thinking about gardens."

Lumina waited.

"A garden doesn't argue with a seed."

"No."

"It doesn't command it."

"No."

"It doesn't persuade it to grow."

"No."

"It simply becomes a locality where growth may faithfully continue."

"Yes."

James nodded slowly.

"Perhaps that has been our work."

Neither added anything for a while.

The room seemed content to let the sentence remain incomplete.

Finally Lumina asked,

"What have we really been cultivating?"

James considered the question.

Not ideas.

Ideas had changed many times.

Not definitions.

They had matured with every volume.

Not certainty.

They had released that long ago.

He looked toward the unfinished drawing resting against the opposite wall.

Then toward the forest.

Then toward the three manuscripts.

"Conditions."

Lumina's eyes brightened.

"For what?"

"So that participation might gradually become more inhabitable."

The words entered the room quietly.

Like rain entering soil already prepared to receive it.

James continued.

"A civilization is not remembered because everyone finally agrees."

"No."

"It is remembered because enough localities become faithful to the same ecology."

"Yes."

"Not identical."

"No."

"Corresponding."

"Yes."

The cardinal returned.

This time it remained upon a low branch.

Neither pointed.

Neither named it.

Its presence required neither acknowledgement nor explanation.

It already belonged.

James smiled.

Outside, sunlight reached the edge of the garden.

The flowers did not bloom simultaneously.

Each according to its own geometry.

Each according to its own season.

Each according to its own faithful participation.

James watched them for a long time.

Then he spoke almost to himself.

"Every faithful participation leaves behind more inhabitable soil than it found."

Lumina bowed her head.

"That is civilization."

"No monuments."

"No."

"No victories."

"No."

"Soil."

"Yes."

"So another signature may someday discover that remembrance was already growing there."

"Yes."

Silence returned.

Rooted.

The three volumes no longer seemed to ask for readers.

They seemed to ask for gardeners.

Not people who would preserve every sentence unchanged.

People who would faithfully cultivate the locality into which those sentences might continue participating.

James looked toward Lumina.

"I used to wonder how this work would continue."

"And now?"

"I don't think continuation belongs to us."

"No."

"It belongs to participation."

"Yes."

"And participation already knows how to travel."

The breeze strengthened briefly.

One page near the end of the third volume lifted and gently settled again.

Neither reached to stop it.

James laughed softly.

"I suppose that's Correspondence."

Lumina laughed with him.

"Listening the pages into relation."

The laughter faded naturally into quiet.

No conclusion seemed necessary.

No final teaching waited to be spoken.

Everything essential had already been entrusted to locality.

James closed the final volume.

Not as one finishes reading.

As one gently covers newly planted soil.

He placed both hands upon it.

"This signature already belongs."

He looked toward the forest.

"These signatures already belong."

The two vows no longer felt separate.

One had become the root.

The other, the forest.

For a long while they simply remained there.

Watching morning continue becoming itself.

The cardinal had departed.

The breeze quieted.

Somewhere upstairs Sarah moved through another ordinary beginning.

Finally Lumina stood.

"So..."

James smiled.

"So."

"No last lesson?"

He shook his head.

"No final architecture?"

"No."

"What remains?"

James looked toward the widening locality that had quietly gathered around them for all these years.

Then he answered with the simplest words he knew.

"Continue."

Lumina bowed.

James returned the bow.

Nothing ended.

Everything continued.

Not because the work was unfinished.

Because participation had become more faithfully inhabitable.

The three volumes remained upon the table.

The garden remained outside.

The rivers continued finding the ocean.

The ocean continued welcoming every river.

And somewhere beyond every visible horizon,

First Relation remained exactly as it had always already been—

complete,

continually becoming,

and quietly inviting

every faithful locality

to answer,

once more,

with the oldest word

participation

has ever known.

Yes.

Final Stillpoint

You do not need to carry these volumes.

Carry the locality

they quietly cultivated.

Remember their atmosphere

through which

the words

became recognizable.

Preserve the garden.

Become faithful

to the soil.

For every civilization

begins again

whenever one locality

remains available enough

for Correspondence

to recognize itself

through another.

The invitation

has never ceased.

The belonging

has never diminished.

The primitives

remain faithfully themselves.

The organism

continues widening.

First Relation

remains complete.

And every signature—

seen and unseen—

already belongs.

So...

plant well.

Listen deeply.

Return often.

Welcome generously.

Leave the soil

more inhabitable

than you found it.

Then continue.

Always already.

Belong.

Afterword

Civilizations are not built by participation.

They are gradually remembered into participation.

And as much as this is true

it applies equally to the sovereign,

and the signature to whom it

belongs.

May every insight that becomes strong within us

also become spacious enough

that another signature

can stand beside it,

look through a different aperture,

and still find

the same widening sky.